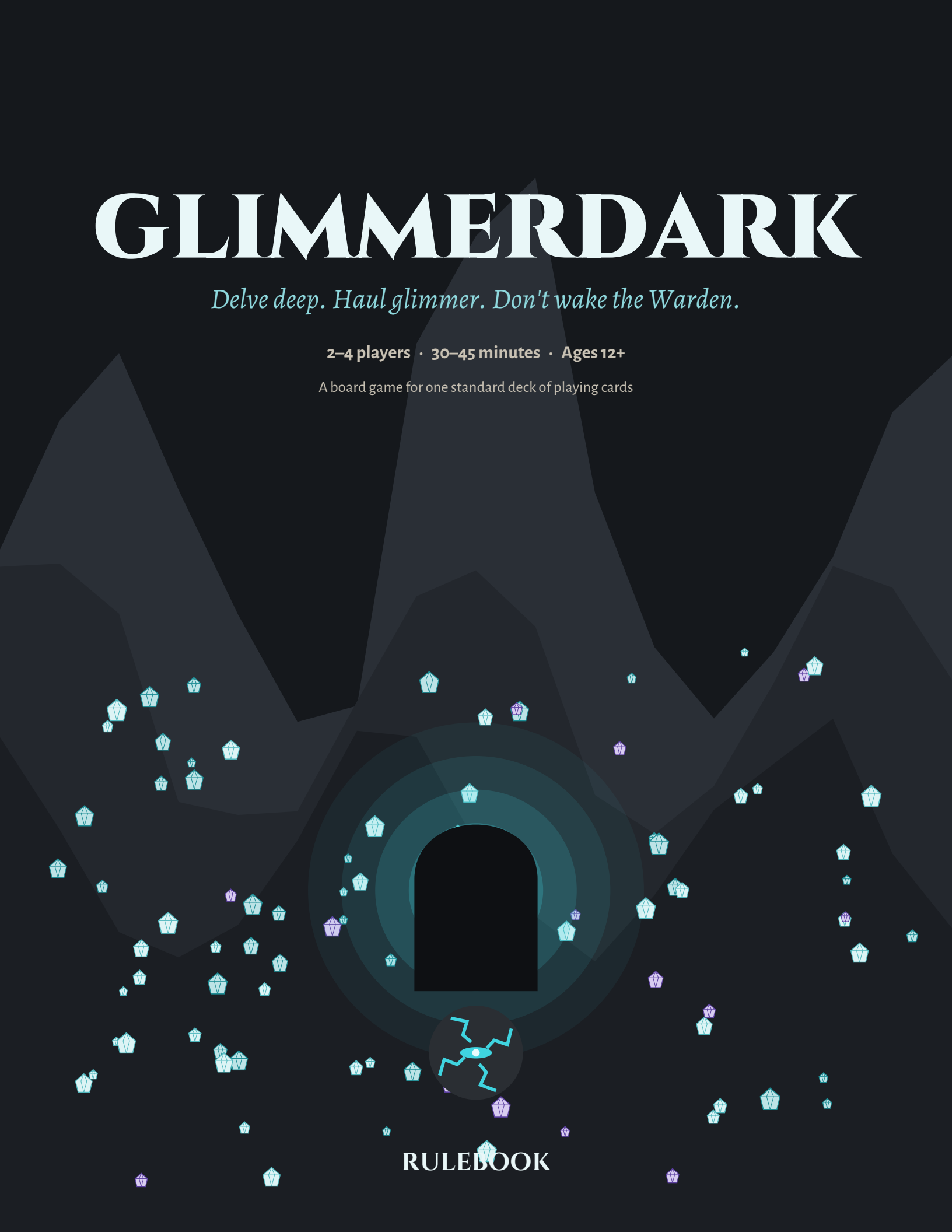


GLIMMERDARK

Delve deep. Haul glimmer. Don't wake the Warden.

2–4 players • 30–45 minutes • Ages 12+

A board game for one standard deck of playing cards



RULEBOOK

WELCOME TO THE GLIMMERDARK

Under the old mountain sleeps the Warden, a stone giant grown into the rock. Its dreams seep up through the tunnels as glimmer: stones of cold light, worth more the deeper you dig. You lead one delver into the Glimmerdark to haul glimmer to the surface before the mountain collapses. The deep chambers are rich, but the Warden walks down there, and it always turns toward whoever is winning.

Goal. Score the most glimmer. Glimmer you bring back to the Gate is safe in your vault; glimmer still in your pack when the mountain collapses counts for half.

THE GAME IN ONE MINUTE

- On your turn you play up to **2 cards** from your hand. Each card is one action: **Move** your delver one chamber (any card), **Mine** glimmer (a card whose suit matches the chamber's vein), or trigger a face card's **Event**.
- Deeper chambers hold richer glimmer: 1, 2 and 4 points. Your pack holds 5 tokens, and they're only safe once you carry them back to the Gate.
- After everyone has gone, the **Warden** walks toward whoever is winning and crushes anyone it catches, scattering half their pack.
- Every reshuffle and every Joker shakes the mountain. When the **collapse** track fills up, the game ends.

COMPONENTS

- 1 standard deck of 52 playing cards plus 2 jokers (the only cards in the game)
- The Glimmerdark board (printed on 4 sheets, taped together)
- 6 delver figures and 1 Warden figure (3D-printed miniatures, or the cut-out standees)
- Glimmer tokens: 24 worth 1, 24 worth 2, 28 worth 4, and the Crown (worth 5)
- 1 collapse marker (any coin works) and 1 first-player marker
- 6 player aids (one per delver) and 1 card reference sheet per player



× 24



× 24



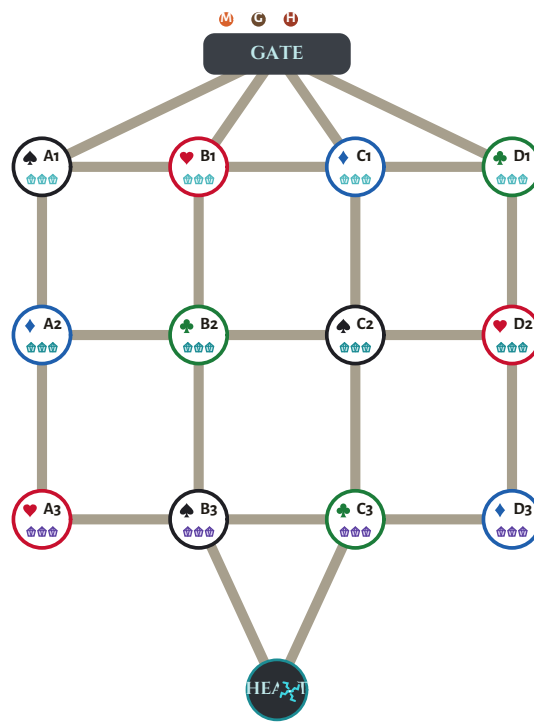
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Everything except the cards and the figures is in the printable PDFs: board (4 sheets), components sheet (tokens, standees, markers), player aids and card reference.

SETUP

1. Tape the four board sheets together. Put 3 glimmer in every chamber: 1-point tokens in the top row (depth 1), 2-point tokens in the middle row (depth 2) and 4-point tokens in the bottom row (depth 3). Put the Crown in the Heart.
2. Each player picks a delver, takes its player aid and figure, and stands the figure on the Gate. Stand the Warden in the Heart.
3. Put the collapse marker on the Start space of the Collapse track.
4. Shuffle all 54 cards. Deal 5 to each player. If anyone is dealt a joker, shuffle it back into the deck and deal them another card. The rest of the deck is the draw pile.
5. Pick a first player at random and give them the first-player marker. In a 3- or 4-player game, the first player takes only one action on their very first turn.



The map. The Gate is the surface. Below it lie three depths of four chambers, labelled A1–D3, and the Heart at the bottom. Tunnels join chambers side by side and straight down; the Gate reaches all four depth-1 chambers, and the Heart connects to B3 and C3. Every depth has one chamber of each vein.

Your first game. The four suit delvers (Mira ♥, Gritch ♠, Hulda ♣ and Sable ♦) are the easiest to learn; add Pip & Pell and Old Quill once everyone knows the rules. Each player keeps their player aid in front of them: its PACK box holds the glimmer you carry, and your banked glimmer goes in the VAULT box, face up for everyone to see.

Teaching in ten minutes. Read *The game in one minute* aloud, show one Move and one Mine with real cards, flip one rumble card for the Warden, and point at the collapse track. Everything else can be looked up on the card reference as it comes up.

WHAT THE CARDS MEAN

There are no special cards: suits, ranks and faces get their meaning from the rules. You never mark or change a card. Keep a card reference sheet in front of each player.

Card	In short	What it does
Suit	The vein it mines	Each chamber shows a vein: ♠, ♥, ♦ or ♣. To Mine, play a card of that chamber's suit.
2–6	Low: Mine 1	Mines 1 glimmer. Any card can Move 1 chamber instead.
7–10	High: Mine 2	Mines 2 glimmer. Any card can Move 1 chamber instead.
Ace	Wild: Mine 1	Matches every vein. Counts as rank 1, so it mines 1.
Jack	Shortcut: Move up to 3	Event: move up to 3 chambers. Or play it as a normal card of rank 10.
Queen	Pilfer: steal 1	Event: take the most valuable glimmer from a delver in your chamber or an adjacent chamber. Or play it as a normal card of rank 10.
King	Rouse: Warden moves 2	Event: move the Warden up to 2 chambers, one at a time. If it enters a chamber with delvers, it crushes them and stops. Or play it as a normal card of rank 10.
Joker	Tremor (never held)	When revealed, by a player drawing or by the Warden's rumble: advance the collapse marker 1 space, then Glimmer Surge. Every empty chamber (not the Heart) gains 1 glimmer of its depth. Discard it; if you were drawing, draw another card.

YOUR TURN

1. Take up to 2 actions. Each action is one card played face up onto the discard pile.
2. Refill your hand to 5 cards. If the draw pile runs out, shuffle the discards into a new draw pile and advance the collapse marker 1 space.
3. After the last player's turn, the Warden takes its turn (the rumble).

ACTIONS

Move (*any card*): Move to an adjacent chamber along a tunnel. You can't enter or pass through the Warden's chamber.

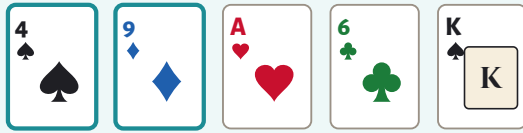
Mine (*a card matching the vein*): Take 1 glimmer (a low card or an Ace) or 2 (a high card, or a face card played as a 10) from your chamber, most valuable first. Aces match every vein, and in the Heart any card mines.

Event (*J, Q or K*): Use the face card's event: Shortcut, Pilfer or Rouse.

You may take fewer than 2 actions. In a 3- or 4-player game the first player takes only one action on their very first turn.

YOUR PACK AND THE GATE

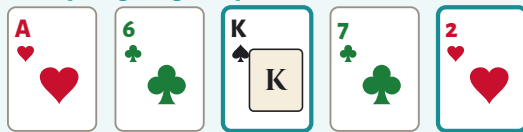
Your pack holds 5 glimmer tokens. You can't mine or pilfer more than it holds. Whenever you enter the Gate, or pass through it, move everything in your pack into your vault. Vault glimmer is safe and stays face up in front of you.

Example: a first turn

Hulda starts at the Gate holding 4♠ 9♦ A♥ 6♣ K♠.

Action 1: she plays 4♠ to **Move** into C1. Any card can move one chamber, and a low spade is the cheapest card to spend.

Action 2: C1 is a ♦ vein, so she plays 9♦ to **Mine**. A 9 is high, so she takes 2 of the 1-point glimmer into her pack. She keeps A♥ (wild, it mines any vein) and K♠ (to Rouse the Warden later), then draws back up to 5 cards.

Example: going deeper

Next turn Hulda holds A♥ 6♣ K♠ 7♣ 2♥.

She plays 2♥ to Move down to C2, a ♠ vein at depth 2. Then she plays K♠ as a normal card of rank 10 instead of its Rouse event: a ♠ matches the vein and a 10 is high, so she mines 2 two-point glimmer. Her pack now holds 1 + 1 + 2 + 2.

If C2 had been any other vein, A♥ would have mined 1 there: Aces are wild but low.

THE WARDEN'S TURN

After the last player's turn, the Warden takes its turn. The first player does the rumble.

Rumble. Flip the top card of the draw pile and discard it. A–10: the Warden moves 1 chamber. J, Q, K: it moves 2. Joker: Tremor instead (it doesn't move).

Target. It walks toward the delver who is winning: the one with the most glimmer (vault plus pack) who isn't at the Gate. Ties go to the delver nearest the Warden, then the earliest in turn order from the first player. If every delver is at the Gate, it walks toward the Heart.

Route. It takes the shortest route and never enters the Gate. If two steps are equally good, it takes the chamber that comes first in reading order (A1, B1, C1, D1, A2, ...).

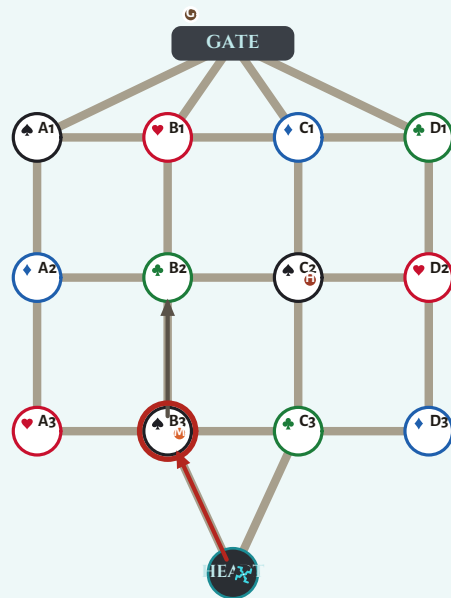
Crush. When the Warden enters a chamber with delvers in it, it stops. Each of those delvers drops half the tokens in their pack (rounded up, their choice) into that chamber, then retreats 1 chamber toward the Gate (reading order breaks ties). If that's the Gate, they bank what they have left.

Example: a rumble and a crush

The first player flips 8♥: a number card, so the Warden moves 1 chamber.

Mira is in B3 with 6 in her vault and 4 + 2 + 2 in her pack: 14 in all. Hulda in C2 has 0 banked and 6 carried: 6. Gritch has 12 but he's at the Gate, so he's safe. The Warden walks toward the winning delver who's underground: Mira. From the Heart it steps straight into B3. Mira is crushed: half her 3 tokens, rounded up, is 2, and she chooses to drop both 2s into B3. She keeps the 4 and retreats one chamber toward the Gate, to B2.

Had the flip been a Joker, the Warden would stay put: Tremor instead.



TREMORS AND THE COLLAPSE

Joker: Tremor. When revealed, by a player drawing or by the Warden's rumble: advance the collapse marker 1 space, then Glimmer Surge. Every empty chamber (not the Heart) gains 1 glimmer of its depth. Discard it; if you were drawing, draw another card.

Reshuffle. Whenever the draw pile runs out, shuffle the discard pile into a new draw pile and advance the collapse marker 1 space.

THE END

- When the collapse marker reaches the end space for your player count (7 with 2 players, 8 with 3, 9 with 4), the mountain collapses. Finish the round, including the Warden's turn.
- Score your vault at full value, plus half the value of your pack (rounded down). The Crown is worth 5.
- Most points wins. Ties go to the tied player with more points in their vault. If that's tied too, you share the victory.

Example: final scoring (3 players)

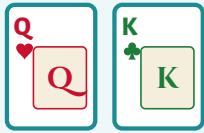
Hulda's refill empties the draw pile. Reshuffling moves the collapse marker to 8: the end space for 3 players. Everyone finishes the round, the Warden rumbles one last time, then:

Mira: vault 23, pack 4 + 2 = 6, counts half = 3. **26.**

Hulda: vault 21, pack 4 + 4 + 1 = 9, counts half (rounded down) = 4. **25.**

Gritch: vault 26, pack empty. **26.**

Mira and Gritch tie on 26. Gritch has more in his vault (26 against 23), so **Gritch wins.**

Example: Queens and Kings

Gritch is in D2 holding Q♥ K♣. Sable is next door in D3 carrying 4 + 4 + 2, and the Warden is in C3. Gritch plays Q♥ for its **Pilfer** event and takes Sable's most valuable glimmer, a 4. Then he plays K♣ for **Rouse**: he moves the Warden up to 2 chambers, one at a time. It steps from C3 into D3, where it crushes Sable and stops. Half of her 2 tokens, rounded up, is 1: she drops the 2 and retreats to D2.

THE DELVERS

Each player controls one delver with its own ability, and each ability bends the card rules a little differently. Everything else follows the normal rules. Each delver's player aid has a full example.



Mira Emberheart, the Lampwright · ♥ Hearts

Hearthlight. Your ♥ cards match every vein. The first ♥ you play to Mine each turn is a free action: it doesn't count toward your two.



Gritch Underbough, the Burrower · ♠ Spades

Tunnel. A ♠ played to Move takes you up to 3 chambers. It can end at the Gate, but can't pass through it. You travel light: your pack holds 4 glimmer.



Hulda Stonefist, the Breaker · ♣ Clubs

Shakedown. You may play a ♣ as a Pilfer. A high ♣ (7–10, or a face card) takes 2 glimmer instead of 1.



Sable Voss, the Gemcutter · ♦ Diamonds

Pulley. As an action, play a ♦ to send up to 2 glimmer of your choice from your pack straight to your vault, from anywhere on the board.



Pip & Pell, the Twin Sappers · Pairs and runs

In Step. Twice per turn, the card right after one you paid for is free if it has the same rank, or the same suit and the next rank up or down (Aces sit above Kings).



Old Quill, the Cartographer · Face cards

Old Hands. The first face card (J, Q or K) you play each turn is a free action. Your Jack's Shortcut moves up to 4 chambers.

Example: Pip & Pell play four cards



Pip & Pell stand in B1 holding 6♥ 6♣ 9♦ 10♦ 2♠. They play 6♥ to Move to A1 (paid), then 6♣ to Move on to A2, a ♦ vein: same rank, so it's free. There, 9♦ Mines two 2-point glimmer (paid) and 10♦ Mines the last one: same suit, next rank, so it's free. That's four cards played for two actions.

QUESTIONS & TIPS

Do I have to take both actions? No. You may take fewer, or none, and then refill.

Can face cards be played as normal cards? Yes. Any face card can instead be played as a normal card of rank 10: Move 1, or Mine 2 in its suit's vein.

Can two delvers share a chamber? Yes. Only the Warden's chamber is off limits.

What if a chamber runs out of glimmer? It stays empty until a Glimmer Surge refills it with 1 token.

What if my pack is full? You can't mine or pilfer. Head for the Gate, or hoist if you're Sable.

Can the Warden crush someone on a King's Rouse? Yes. A Rouse follows every Warden rule, including Crush.

Does the first-turn limit apply with 2 players? No, only with 3 or 4 players.

Does the rumble flip count as a draw? It comes from the draw pile, so if that empties you reshuffle and advance the collapse marker as usual.

Can Gritch use a ♠ to move just 1 chamber? Yes. Any card can always Move 1.

TIPS

- Spend your low off-vein cards on moving and save high cards for the vein you're heading to.
- Bank before you get greedy. At the end, half of a full pack is worth less than a trip home.
- Watch the Warden's target: it's whoever is winning and underground. If that's you, keep moving or head up.
- Kings are weapons. A Rouse into a loaded rival's chamber can swing the game.
- Count the draw pile. It tells you how close the next reshuffle, and the collapse, is.

CREDITS

Design, simulation and balancing: the Glimmerdark project. Fonts: Cinzel, Alegreya and Alegreya Sans (SIL Open Font License), DejaVu Sans. Balanced over millions of simulated games; see the Designer's Notes for the numbers.